

The Great War: Causes & Outbreak

Student Workbook

Name: _____ Class: _____

Assessment Levels Guide

- **Emerging (1-2):** Basic understanding of key events.
- **Emerging+ (3):** Describes events with some historical details.
- **Expected (4-5):** Explains causes, consequences, and significance clearly.
- **Expected+ (6-7):** Analyzes context and links different factors.
- **Greater Depth (8-9):** Highly detailed, analytical, and evaluates complex changes.



The Great War: Causes & Outbreak

Source A: A political cartoon published in Puck Magazine (1909) satirising the intense naval arms race between Britain and Germany.

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Do Now	Level	Teacher Comment
How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?	/ 5		
To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?	/ 10		
Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?	/ 10		
Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?	/ 10		
Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?	/ 10		
Assessment Option 1: The July Crisis Domino Flowchart	N/A		
Assessment Option 2: The M.A.I.N. Significance Diamond	N/A		

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Do Now	Level	Teacher Comment
Assessment Option 3: Source Utility Analysis	N/A		
Assessment Option 4: The Historians' Debate	N/A		
Final Unit Grade:			

How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

Q1. What are the two opposing figures doing in this 1871 painting by Anton von Werner, and why is this event significant?

Source A: Anton von Werner, 'The Proclamation of the German Empire at Versailles', painted in 1885.



What is this source showing? This painting depicts the official birth of the unified German Empire inside the Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles in 1871. France was defeated and forced to host this ceremony in its own royal palace. This created a deep, lasting feeling of humiliation and anger in France, leading to a desire for revenge (*revanche*) that would eventually help spark WWI.

Q1. What are the two opposing figures doing in this 1871 painting by Anton von Werner, and why is this event significant?

Chronological Domino Flowchart

Score: / 5

Task: The historical events below are out of order. Read them carefully, then use your pen to **draw arrows connecting the boxes** in the correct chronological and causal order (Event A → Event B → Event C...).

June 1914

The Spark in Sarajevo

The Assassination of the Archduke

1906

The Naval Arms Race

The Launch of HMS Dreadnought

1907

Encirclement & Alliances

The Triple Entente System

1897

Imperial Rivalries

The Place in the Sun speech

1871

The Unification of Germany

The Franco-Prussian War

1. Looking at this long-term timeline, which factor do you think was the most dangerous necessary cause of the war?

Map A: Alsace-Lorraine Border Region (1871)



Simplified map showing Alsace-Lorraine on the border between France and the new German Empire.

Vocabulary Check

Style: Contextual Cloze

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Alsace-Lorraine | Ems Telegram | Reparations | Siege

In 1870, Chancellor Bismarck edited the _____ to trick France into war. After a devastating _____ of Paris, France was forced to pay massive _____ and hand over the vital territory of _____.

There was no country called Germany until 1871. Instead, central Europe was a fragmented collection of independent small states loosely joined only by language and local customs. The most powerful, heavily militaristic state among them was the northern kingdom of Prussia. Desiring to unite these states, Prussia's brilliant, ruthless Chancellor Otto von Bismarck first grouped the northern states into the **North German Confederation**. To complete his dream of a single, mighty empire, Bismarck desperately needed the independent southern German states to unite with the north. He realized that nothing would unite these separate states faster than a shared national enemy.

Q3. To what extent did the maps of central Europe fundamentally change prior to 1871? Use the term "North German Confederation" in your answer.

Bismarck's opportunity arrived in July 1870, when King Wilhelm sent him a holiday dispatch describing a friendly meeting with the French ambassador. Bismarck carefully edited and shortened the text of this message—now famously known as the **Ems Telegram**—before releasing it to the international press. The edited text read as though the Prussian King had explicitly insulted the French government. Horrified at this public

blow to their national pride, France predictably declared war on 19 July 1870. Bismarck's trap worked flawlessly: the independent southern German states immediately united behind Prussia.

Q4. Describe the diplomatic trick Chancellor Otto von Bismarck used to manufacture a war with France in 1870.

Prussia's military strategy relied on two distinct advantages. First, they utilized an **advanced railway network** to mobilise and deploy 500,000 highly trained troops with astonishing speed. Second, they equipped their forces with **Krupp steel artillery**, which fired much faster and further than French guns. The smaller French force of 180,000 was completely caught off guard. During the terrible Siege of Metz, the best French troops were entirely surrounded. When the remaining French forces attempted to break the lines at the Battle of Sedan on 1 September, they suffered 17,000 casualties and over 21,000 soldiers were captured—including the French Emperor Napoleon III. Following a brutal four-month winter siege of Paris, the capital surrendered on 28 January 1871.

Q5. Identify two distinct military advantages that allowed the Prussian-led German army to quickly defeat the conventional French forces.

The war permanently transformed the balance of power. In a final, agonizing humiliation for France, the German Empire was officially proclaimed inside the Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles—the historic home of French royalty. The peace treaty forced three severe penalties upon France: it ceded the strategic industrial border provinces of **Alsace-Lorraine**, was forced to pay a crushing war fine of **5 billion francs** over five

years, and was forced to **host a German occupation army**. This deep humiliation shattered French national pride and planted a bitter seed of resentment. Fearing eventual French revenge, German Field Marshal Alfred von Schlieffen began drawing up a military master plan in 1897 to quickly knock out France first if Germany ever faced a simultaneous war with Russia.

Q6. List the three severe penalties forced upon France by the victorious German Empire in the 1871 peace treaty.

Following the crushing defeat of France in 1871, German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck understood that France would never forgive the loss of Alsace-Lorraine. His greatest fear was that France would form an alliance with another major European power—specifically Russia—which would force Germany to fight a devastating "two-front war" if conflict ever broke out.

Q7. Explain why the loss of Alsace-Lorraine and the ceremony at Versailles created a long-term "nightmare" for European peace.

To prevent this, Bismarck spent the next twenty years weaving a complex, dizzying web of alliances and secret treaties designed entirely to keep France diplomatically isolated. He formed the Triple Alliance with Austria-Hungary and Italy, and signed a secret Reinsurance Treaty with Russia. Bismarck's diplomatic genius lay in his ability to juggle these competing empires, ensuring that Germany always had more friends than enemies.

However, when a young, ambitious Kaiser Wilhelm II took the throne in 1888, he dismissed Bismarck and foolishly allowed the treaty with Russia to expire. Within years, Bismarck's nightmare became a reality: France and Russia signed a military alliance. The brilliant diplomatic safety net that Bismarck had built was gone, leaving Germany surrounded and forcing the German military to start planning for the exact scenario Bismarck had dreaded.

Bismarck vs. Wilhelm: A Clash of Strategy

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Q8. Evaluate how the change in leadership from Bismarck to Kaiser Wilhelm II fundamentally altered Germany's strategic position in Europe.

Historian's Corner: The 'Master Planner' Debate

Historians debate whether Bismarck was a genius 'master planner' who plotted the Franco-Prussian War years in advance, or merely a brilliant opportunist who reacted to events (like the Ems Telegram) as they happened. A.J.P. Taylor famously argued Bismarck just rode the wave of events.

GCSE Cross-Source Analysis

How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the reasons for French hatred of Germany after 1871?

“We must never forget the humiliation of 1871. The German Empire was proclaimed in our own Palace of Versailles, tearing away the bleeding wounds of Alsace and Lorraine. They have stolen our iron and our factories, and forced us to pay a crushing ransom of 5 billion francs. Every French child must grow up with one single thought: to rebuild our army and take back what was stolen from the motherland.”

Source A: Adapted from a French school textbook, published in Paris, 1885.

“France will never forgive us for taking Alsace-Lorraine. The peace we have forced upon them has left a bitter resentment that will not fade. We must accept that a French war of revenge is a certainty in the future. Therefore, our entire diplomatic focus must be to ensure she never finds an ally to help her take it back. As long as France remains diplomatically isolated, particularly from Russia, Germany will remain secure.”

Source B: Adapted from a private letter written by German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck to a fellow diplomat, 1872.

Source Evaluation Notes

Source	N.O.P. (Nature, Origin, Purpose)	Content (What it shows/says)	Contextual Knowledge
A			
B			

- Teacher Comment:

To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

Q1. Look closely at the man standing over Africa. What is his posture suggesting about imperial ambitions?

Source A: John Tenniel, 'The Greedy Boy', a British political cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1885.



What is this source showing? *This British cartoon satirizes Germany's Chancellor Otto von Bismarck as a "greedy boy" grabbing slices of a pudding that represents colonial territories in Africa and New Guinea. This reflects British anxiety and suspicion about Germany's aggressive efforts to build a global empire, which threatened Britain's status as the world's leading power.*

Q1. Look closely at the man standing over Africa. What is his posture suggesting about imperial ambitions?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Who was the first Emperor of the newly unified Germany in 1871?

2. Which brilliant Chancellor united the German states?

3. Which country was humiliatingly defeated in the Franco-Prussian War?

4. What strategic border territory did Germany take in 1871?

5. What is the French word for their desire for revenge?

6. Explain how Bismarck used the Ems Telegram to trap France into a war.

7. Detail the two military advantages the Prussian army possessed.

8. Why was the location of the German Empire's proclamation so humiliating for France?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Map A: Partition of Africa (1914)



Map B: The Global Imperial Lanes



Vocabulary Check

Style: Vocabulary Mapping

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Imperialism | Scramble for Africa | Empire | Colony

Your Sentence:

By the turn of the 20th century, the Great Powers of Europe were locked in a fierce, competitive race to conquer and maintain overseas empires. Colonies had become vital status symbols of industrial wealth and global importance. Each territory provided cheap raw materials to feed the factories of the ruling nation, while simultaneously serving as locked-down markets to purchase the home country's manufactured goods. This race had been formalized at the **1884 Berlin Conference**, where European leaders partitioned Africa among themselves without consulting any Africans. Among the territories partitioned, the **Congo Free State** stood out as a site of extreme exploitation, owned personally by King Leopold II of Belgium.

Q3. Explain two distinct economic reasons why possessing overseas colonies was vital to the industrial growth of a Great Power.

Great Britain possessed the vastest overseas empire in human history. Because Great Britain was an island nation, its entire imperial network relied heavily on open sea routes. Thousands of British merchant ships sailed the oceans daily, and the Royal Navy was given absolute priority to keep these global sea lanes clear of foreign rivals. Crucially, Britain controlled the **Suez Canal** in Egypt to secure its vital shipping lanes to India. Any challenge to this naval dominance was viewed by British politicians as a direct threat to the survival of the British Empire. France held the second-largest empire, focusing heavily on territories in North and West Africa. Having suffered the bitter humiliation of losing Alsace-Lorraine to Germany in 1871, French politicians fiercely guarded their colonies to protect their remaining international reputation. However, imperial expansion was fraught with danger; in 1898, Britain and France nearly went to war during the **Fashoda Incident**, a tense military standoff over control of the Upper Nile in Sudan.

Q4. Why did French politicians feel it was absolutely vital to maintain a firm hold on their remaining global colonies after 1871?

The entire geopolitical landscape destabilized when Germany entered the race. Having only unified in 1871, Germany was a new nation right in the middle of Europe, but its industry was growing rapidly. The ambitious German Kaiser Wilhelm II and his politicians wanted Germany to match the global influence of Britain and France. In a fiery speech to the German parliament on 6 December 1897, Foreign Secretary Bernhard von Bülow announced that Germany would no longer stand aside, famously demanding Germany's own "place in the sun".

Germany rapidly seized territories across the globe, including the Cameroons, East Africa, Togo, and the Pacific colony of **Kaiser-Wilhelmsland** in Papua New Guinea. This aggressive push led to direct clashes. In 1911, the **Agadir Crisis** erupted when Germany sent a gunboat, the **SMS Panther**, to the Moroccan port of **Agadir** in an attempt to challenge French influence. The standoff ended when Germany recognized **France** as the protector of Morocco in exchange for minor territories in the Congo. To hold and defend this new empire, German politicians announced plans to construct a massive battle fleet. This move deeply alarmed Great Britain. British politicians regarded

Germany's colonial and naval ambitions as an aggressive attempt to undermine the British Empire, while German leaders increasingly viewed Britain as a hostile obstacle standing in the way of Germany's legitimate right to historical greatness.

Q5. Explain how Germany's sudden desire to build a naval fleet to protect its new colonies acted as a cause of friction with Great Britain.

Q6. What specific geographical territory did Foreign Secretary Bernhard von Bülow target when he demanded a "place in the sun" for Germany? (P3 & P4)

In 1904, Britain and France ended centuries of bitter rivalry by signing the Entente Cordiale, a friendly agreement to resolve colonial disputes. Kaiser Wilhelm II of Germany was furious; he believed this friendship was designed to encircle Germany. To test the strength of this new bond, the Kaiser decided to deliberately provoke a crisis in North Africa, assuming the British would not actually risk war to defend French interests.

In 1905, the Kaiser arrived in Tangier, Morocco, declaring his support for Moroccan independence against French influence. He expected the Entente Cordiale to fracture under pressure. Instead, the exact opposite happened: at the Algeiras Conference in 1906, Britain firmly backed France, leaving Germany diplomatically humiliated and isolated, supported only by Austria-Hungary.

The Kaiser repeated this dangerous gamble in 1911 (the Agadir Crisis) by sending the gunboat SMS Panther to the Moroccan coast. Once again, Britain stood by France, and the British navy was even placed on a war footing. Wilhelm's clumsy attempts at 'gunboat

diplomacy' completely backfired. Rather than breaking the Entente Cordiale, his aggression convinced Britain and France that Germany was an unpredictable threat, pushing the two nations into a much tighter military partnership.



The Gamble of Weltpolitik

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Q7. Explain why Kaiser Wilhelm's strategy of testing the Entente Cordiale during the Moroccan Crises was a massive strategic failure for Germany.

Historian's Corner: The Primat der Innenpolitik

Some historians (like Eckart Kehr) argue that Wilhelm II's aggressive Weltpolitik was actually driven by domestic politics. By creating foreign enemies, the Kaiser hoped to distract the German working class from voting for socialist parties at home.

GCSE Cross-Source Analysis

How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the impact of Weltpolitik on international relations?



Source A: A British political cartoon from 1897 showing Kaiser Wilhelm II.

“We do not want to put anyone in the shade, but we too demand our place in the sun.”

Source B: Speech by German Foreign Minister Bernhard von Bülow to the Reichstag, 1897.

Source Evaluation Notes

Source	N.O.P. (Nature, Origin, Purpose)	Content (What it shows/says)	Contextual Knowledge
A			
B			

Final Written Evaluation

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

Q1. This blueprint represents the HMS Dreadnought. Why would this ship make all other navies obsolete?

Source A: Official technical blueprint showing the design and armament of HMS Dreadnought, published in 1906.



***What is this source showing?** This is a technical naval diagram of HMS Dreadnought, a revolutionary British battleship launched in 1906. It was so fast and heavily armed that it instantly made all existing warships in the world obsolete (useless). This triggered a frantic naval arms race between Britain and Germany, as both countries rushed to build as many Dreadnoughts as possible.*

Q1. This blueprint represents the HMS Dreadnought. Why would this ship make all other navies obsolete?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

2. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

3. Why was the Franco-Russian Alliance a strategic disaster for Germany?

4. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

5. Describe the impact of Britain abandoning its policy of 'Splendid Isolation'.

6. Evaluate the role of Wilhelm II's personality in destabilizing Europe.

7. Who dismissed Otto von Bismarck in 1890?

8. What strategic territory did Germany take from France in 1871?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Map A: The North Sea & Naval Chokepoints



Vocabulary Check

Style: Mini-Frayer Model

Complete the Frayer Model for the term: ***Dreadnought***

Definition	Historical Example
Non-Example / Sketch	Your own sentence

For nearly a century following the Battle of Trafalgar in 1805, Great Britain had ruled the world's oceans without any major international challenge, possessing the most powerful navy on earth. As an island nation with a massive global empire, Britain relied on its naval supremacy to protect its trade routes, secure resource lifelines, and defend its home shores from European threats. To maintain this supremacy, Britain adhered to the , a strict naval policy stating that the Royal Navy must always be at least equal to or larger than the next two most powerful navies in the world combined.

Q3. Describe the 'Two-Power Standard' and explain why Great Britain adhered to this strict naval policy.

Everything changed fundamentally in 1898 when Germany's new emperor, Kaiser Wilhelm II, announced his clear intention to build a powerful German navy. The Kaiser believed that if Germany was ever to become a true world power, it had to explicitly challenge the global dominance of the British fleet. In 1898 and 1900, the German

government passed the historic German Navy Laws, which ordered the rapid construction of a massive fleet, including 19 battleships in the first law and an additional 38 in the second. To back this policy, the German naval chief, Admiral Tirpitz, established the Navy League. This massive organization arranged civilian tours of industrial shipyards and delivered public lectures across Germany to stimulate intense public interest and build a fierce sense of patriotism among ordinary citizens.

Q4. Detail what the German Navy Laws of 1898 and 1900 explicitly ordered the German industrial shipyards to construct.

Q5. Explain how Admiral Tirpitz used the Navy League to manufacture civilian support and patriotism for Germany's expanding fleet.

Q6. Explain why maintaining a massive navy was a matter of survival for Great Britain, but was viewed as a matter of status and power for Germany. (P1 & P2)

British politicians were profoundly alarmed by Germany's actions. They believed that Germany's expanding High Seas Fleet was being designed specifically for a future military conflict with the British Grand Fleet. To explain the danger, British politicians pointed out the fundamental difference in each nation's security needs.

Britain's defensive response was to design and construct the most powerful warship ever created: HMS *Dreadnought*. Launched in 1906, this vessel was so advanced in its speed, armor plating, and long-range rotating turrets that every existing battleship on earth was rendered instantly obsolete overnight. Rather than stopping the competition, HMS *Dreadnought* inadvertently reset the score to zero, giving Germany a chance to compete on equal terms. Germany immediately responded by manufacturing its own version of the battleship, the *SMS Rheinland*. The naval arms race was officially underway, with both nations building more and more of these massive, expensive weapons. By 1914, Germany had successfully doubled the size of its navy to become the second-largest naval power in the world, leaving Britain deeply suspicious of its motives.

Q7. Identify three specific technological features of HMS Dreadnought that made it superior to all previous warships.

This competitive race culminated in a highly strategic naval standoff. The British Grand Fleet was stationed at its primary home base at in Scotland, while the German High Seas Fleet was based at on the North Sea coast. Both fleets expected a massive, decisive battle in the . To facilitate the rapid movement of its massive new dreadnoughts between the Baltic Sea and the North Sea, Germany widened the , completing the project in 1914 just before the outbreak of war.

Before 1906, Britain ruled the waves with a policy known as the 'Two-Power Standard'—a rule stating the Royal Navy must be at least as large as the next two biggest navies combined. Germany, despite passing ambitious Naval Laws under Admiral von Tirpitz, was struggling to catch up. But in 1906, Britain launched a ship that accidentally leveled the playing field.

The HMS Dreadnought was a technological marvel. It was faster, heavily armored, and carried ten massive 12-inch guns, making every other battleship on earth instantly obsolete. While the Dreadnought was a triumph of British engineering, it contained a fatal strategic flaw: because all older ships were now worthless, Britain's massive head start in naval numbers was suddenly wiped out.

Germany recognized the opportunity immediately. The naval race was no longer about total ships, but about who could build the most 'Dreadnought-class' vessels. By revolutionizing naval warfare, Britain had essentially hit the reset button on the arms race, giving Germany a realistic chance to challenge British naval supremacy from scratch. The ensuing desperate scramble to build Dreadnoughts consumed the budgets and political rhetoric of both nations up until 1914.

Q8. Explain how the launching of HMS Dreadnought in 1906 represented an industrial turning point in the naval arms race, rather than maintaining the status quo. (P4 & P8)

The Naval Race: A Self-Fulfilling Prophecy?

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Q9. How did the invention of the HMS Dreadnought ironically endanger British naval supremacy despite being a British invention?

Historian's Corner: The Anglo-German Antagonism

Paul Kennedy argues that the naval arms race was the single most decisive factor in turning Britain from a neutral observer into Germany's enemy, as the threat of a German navy fundamentally challenged Britain's core survival strategy.

GCSE Cross-Source Analysis

How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the effects of the Anglo-German naval arms race?



Source A: Official technical blueprint of HMS Dreadnought, 1906.

"We want eight, and we won't wait!"

Source B: Popular British political slogan chanted by the public in 1909.

Source Evaluation Notes

Source	N.O.P. (Nature, Origin, Purpose)	Content (What it shows/says)	Contextual Knowledge
A			
B			

Final Written Evaluation

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

Q1. Study the intertwined hands and figures in this map. What does it suggest about how a local conflict might spread?

Source A: 'The Chain of Friendship', an American cartoon published in the Brooklyn Eagle, July 1914.



What is this source showing? This cartoon shows how the complex web of alliances dragged all the European powers into war. Serbia is threatened by Austria, who is threatened by Russia, who is threatened by Germany, and so on.

Q1. Study the intertwined hands and figures in this map. What does it suggest about how a local conflict might spread?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

2. What was the 'Two-Power Standard'?

3. Why did Germany feel it needed a massive high seas fleet?

4. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

5. What was the popular British slogan chanted by the public in 1909?

6. Why did Britain feel their survival depended on massive naval supremacy?

7. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

8. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

9. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

10. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

Diagram A: The Alliance System (1914)



The complex web of treaties that dragged Europe into a global war.

Map A: European Military Alliance Blocs (1914)



Vocabulary Check

Style: Contextual Cloze

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Triple Entente | Triple Alliance | Reinsurance Treaty | Encirclement

Bismarck feared a two-front war and created the _____ to keep Russia friendly. However, after his dismissal, Germany faced a nightmare scenario: _____ by hostile powers. Europe split into two armed camps: the _____ (Britain, France, Russia) and the _____ (Germany, Austria-Hungary, Italy).

As European empires expanded and resources grew tightly contested, nations looked for ways to keep themselves safe from sudden attack by their rivals. The primary strategy chosen by European monarchs and statesmen was the construction of binding military alliances. Gradually, over several decades, Europe was carved up into two massively armed, opposing camps.

By 1907, the European alliance system had solidified into two balanced groups. On one side stood the _____, consisting of the central European bloc of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. On the opposing side sat the _____, uniting Great Britain, France, and Russia. At the time, contemporary newspapers and diplomats argued that this delicate division of power would successfully maintain world peace. The logic was simple: going to war with any single member of an alliance meant triggering an immediate, terrible war against the entire opposing bloc. No statesman, they believed, would be reckless enough to initiate such a disaster.

Q4. Identify the specific member countries that made up the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente by 1907.

Q5. Explain the diplomatic logic of how the alliance system was theoretically supposed to keep European nations safe from a outbreak of war.

However, the alliance system did not create a sense of safety; instead, it bred intense suspicion and paranoia. The German Kaiser and his military planners viewed the Triple Entente not as a peaceful defensive bloc, but as a hostile circle of enemies designed to trap them. Historians note that from the German perspective, this amounted to a deliberate policy of meant to block Germany's legitimate right to become a global power. Crucially, the German High Command and Austria-Hungary's Chief of the General Staff, (who repeatedly advocated for a preventive war to crush Serbia), believed that a massive European war was . They feared that Russia's rapid industrialization and military growth would soon overwhelm Germany, making a preventative war necessary before Russia became too powerful. This deep-seated fear reinforced the necessity of the Schlieffen Plan—to aggressively smash France first before the massive Russian army could fully mobilise to attack from the east.

Q6. According to Germany's military leaders, explain why a European war was considered "inevitable and necessary" rather than avoidable.

Concurrently, the nature of war was becoming highly industrialization-driven. All the Great Powers utilized their factories to engage in a massive land-based arms race. Between 1906 and 1914, steel production in Germany skyrocketed to over 17 million tonnes, vastly outpacing Britain and France combined, to forge heavy artillery and armaments. Millions of kilometers of railway tracks were laid down across the continent for a single strategic purpose: to move hundreds of thousands of uniformed soldiers to the front lines within hours of a crisis breaking out. By 1914, Europe had been transformed into a volatile, high-density powder keg where any single local spark would automatically pull all the Great Powers into a total global slaughter.

Q7. Detail how the massive expansion of steel production and railway tracks across Europe altered the speed and scale of army mobilization.

Q8. Explain how the transformation of Europe into two "armed camps" by 1914 represented a dangerous change in international relations compared to the traditional balance of power.

Following the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand, Austria-Hungary wanted to crush Serbia but feared Russian intervention. To proceed safely, Austria needed a guarantee of German support. On July 5th, 1914, Kaiser Wilhelm II issued what historians call the 'Blank Check'—an unconditional promise that Germany would stand by Austria-Hungary, even if their actions provoked a war with Russia.

This 'Blank Check' is one of the most debated actions in modern history. Some historians argue the Kaiser was acting out of impulsive loyalty to his murdered friend, not expecting the crisis to escalate beyond a localized Balkan war. They point to the fact that Wilhelm went on a sailing cruise immediately after giving the promise, suggesting he did not believe a global conflict was imminent.

However, other historians argue that the German High Command deliberately used the 'Blank Check' to push Austria into war. Knowing that Russia's military was rapidly modernizing and would soon be too powerful to defeat, German generals believed that if a European war was inevitable, it was better to fight it in 1914 rather than wait. By giving Austria unconditional support, Germany ensured the crisis would explode into a continental conflict.

The Powder Keg: Nationalism vs. Empire

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Q9. Was the 'Blank Check' a reckless mistake by the Kaiser, or a calculated move by the German military to trigger a necessary war? Use historical reasoning to justify your stance.

Historian's Corner: The 'Powder Keg' Inevitability

Was war inevitable in the Balkans? Richard Evans argues that the complex alliance system turned the Balkans into a doomsday machine, where any small conflict was mathematically guaranteed to drag all the Great Powers into a general war.

GCSE Cross-Source Analysis

How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the threat posed by Serbia to Austria-Hungary?



Source A: Map of the Balkans showing the expansion of Serbia after 1913.

“Serbia is a viper that must be crushed. If we do not destroy them now, our empire will be torn apart by Slavic nationalism.”

Source B: Diary entry of the Austro-Hungarian Chief of Staff, Conrad von Hötzendorf, 1913.

Source Evaluation Notes

Source	N.O.P. (Nature, Origin, Purpose)	Content (What it shows/says)	Contextual Knowledge
A			
B			

Final Written Evaluation

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

Q1. Look at the men sitting on the 'Balkan Troubles' pot. What are they desperately trying to prevent?

Source A: Leonard Raven-Hill, 'The Boiling Point', a British political cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1912.



What is this source showing? *This famous cartoon represents the Balkans region as a boiling pot of ethnic and nationalistic tensions. The leaders of the European Great Powers (Britain, Germany, France, Russia, Austria-Hungary) are shown sitting on the lid, struggling to prevent the pot from exploding into a major European war.*

Q1. Look at the men sitting on the 'Balkan Troubles' pot. What are they desperately trying to prevent?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Which three countries made up the Triple Entente?

2. Which three countries made up the Triple Alliance?

3. Explain the theoretical logic of how the alliance system was supposed to keep peace.

4. Why did the alliance system actually increase paranoia instead of security?

5. What military plan did Germany create to avoid a long two-front war?

6. Which neutral country did the Schlieffen Plan require invading?

7. What feeling of being surrounded by enemies haunted German planners?

8. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

9. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

10. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

Diagram A: The July Crisis Domino Effect



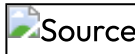
How a single assassination in the Balkans escalated into a world war within a month.

Map A: The Balkan Peninsula (1914)



Simplified map of the highly unstable Balkan Peninsula in 1914.

Map B: Inset - Sarajevo, 28 June 1914: The Fatal Route



Vocabulary Check

Style: Vocabulary Mapping

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Assassination | Black Hand | Ultimatum | Mobilisation

Your Sentence:

The region of south-east Europe known as the Balkans had once been ruled securely by the Turkish Ottoman Empire. However, as Turkish power weakened across the 19th and early 20th centuries, the Ottoman Empire lost control. Different Balkan states began fiercely demanding their own independence, sparking a series of local Balkan Wars that left the entire area a hotbed of hatred, suspicion, and aggressive militarism.

For the neighboring empire of Austria-Hungary, this was an absolute nightmare. Austria-Hungary was a vast empire containing many different nationalities who wanted independence. Its politicians deeply feared that if Serbian nationalism rose unchecked, the millions of Serbs living inside the Austro-Hungarian borders would rebel, causing the entire empire to collapse. Tensions exploded in 1908 when Austria officially the provinces

of Bosnia and Herzegovina, directly absorbing thousands of furious Serbs into its territory. In response, a group of radical Serbian army officers formed a secret terrorist society dedicated to uniting all Serbs by force: the Black Hand.

Q3. Explain why the rise of independent Balkan states and Serbian nationalism represented a catastrophic nightmare for the Austro-Hungarian Empire.

By June 1914, the Balkan powder keg was ready to blow. To show the rebellious Serbs who was boss, the heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, Archduke Franz Ferdinand, scheduled a high-profile state visit to Sarajevo, the capital of Bosnia. The date chosen was June 28—the sacred national day of the Serbian people. Thanks to extensive press publicity, the Black Hand knew exactly where the Archduke's open-top car would drive along the riverfront. Six young assassins positioned themselves along the quay armed with bombs, pistols, and suicide capsules.

The initial assassination attempts failed completely. One terrorist couldn't get his gun out, another went home out of pity, and a third threw a bomb that bounced off the Archduke's car and exploded under the vehicle behind. Furious, Franz Ferdinand canceled the rest of his itinerary and decided to head back to the train station, ordering his driver to stop by the hospital first to visit the wounded officers. However, the route map was altered and the drivers took a critical wrong turn onto Franz Josef Street. Realizing the error, the drivers stopped and attempted to reverse.

Q4. Detail how the structural failure of the first bomb plot inadvertently led to the exact scenario where Gavrilo Princip was able to shoot the Archduke.

The car ground to a halt a fraction of a second away from where 19-year-old Black Hand assassin Gavrilo Princip was standing. Seizing his unexpected luck, Princip stepped forward, pulled his pistol, and fired twice into the car. One bullet tore through the Archduke's throat; the second struck his wife, Sophie, in the stomach. Both died within minutes.

This local double-murder triggered a rapid, unstoppable countdown to global war. Backed by Germany's unconditional promise of absolute military support—known as the 'blank cheque'—Austria-Hungary issued a harsh, unacceptable ultimatum to Serbia on July 23. Blaming Serbia for the assassination, they subsequently declared war on July 28, shelling Belgrade. Russia immediately mobilised its massive army to protect its fellow Slavic state, Serbia. Because the German Schlieffen Plan required an immediate land invasion of France through neutral Belgium, Great Britain was bound by the to honor its promise to protect Belgian neutrality. On August 4, 1914, Britain declared war on Germany. The complex system of long-term alliances, imperial greed, and land arms races had successfully dragged the entire world down the path to an unprecedented slaughter.

Q5. Outline the chronological sequence of events from July 23 to August 4, 1914, that transformed a local Balkan assassination into a total European war.

The 37 days between the assassination in Sarajevo and the outbreak of war are known as the July Crisis. During this frenzied period, diplomats and monarchs across Europe scrambled to react as the rigid alliance system began pulling their nations toward the abyss. What makes the July Crisis so tragic is how many desperate, last-minute attempts were made to hit the brakes.

The most famous of these attempts was the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams'—a series of deeply personal, frantic messages exchanged between Kaiser Wilhelm II and Tsar Nicholas II of Russia, who were cousins. Both monarchs pleaded with each other to stop military

mobilizations, signing their telegrams with familiar nicknames. However, neither leader was willing to be the first to stand their armies down, fearing they would be left defenseless if the other attacked.

Q6. What does the desperate tone of the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams' reveal about the monarchs' control over the escalating July Crisis?

Ultimately, the crisis revealed a terrifying reality: the civilian politicians and monarchs had lost control of the situation to their military generals. Military timetables, such as Germany's rigid Schlieffen Plan and Russia's immense mobilization schedules, were so inflexible that once the train of war started moving, it could not be stopped. The alliance system, intended as a deterrent, had instead become a doomsday machine.

Q7. Explain why it is historically inaccurate to describe the First World War strictly as a 'European' conflict in 1914.

When war broke out in 1914, it was not just a European conflict. Because of the aggressive Scramble for Colonies (Lesson 2), millions of colonized people across Africa, Asia, and the Middle East were dragged into a war they had no part in causing. Without the immense sacrifices of these colonial troops and laborers, the European empires would have collapsed.



The July Crisis (1914) - The Domino Effect

The July Crisis: Inevitable or Preventable?

Historian's Corner: The Fischer Controversy

In 1961, German historian Fritz Fischer shocked the world by arguing that Germany deliberately caused WWI to achieve world power status. He pointed to the 'Blank Cheque' as evidence that Germany actively pushed Austria into war, knowing it would provoke Russia.

GCSE Cross-Source Analysis

How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the causes of the outbreak of World War I?



Source A: 'The Boiling Point', a British cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1912.

"You may rest assured that His Majesty will faithfully stand by Austria-Hungary, as is required by the obligations of his alliance and of his ancient friendship."

Source B: The 'Blank Cheque' telegram sent from Germany to Austria-Hungary, 5 July 1914.

Source Evaluation Notes

Source	N.O.P. (Nature, Origin, Purpose)	Content (What it shows/says)	Contextual Knowledge
A			
B			

Final Written Evaluation

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

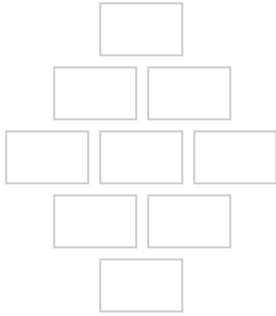
Teacher Comment:

Assessment Option 2: The M.A.I.N. Significance

Diamond

Instructions: Arrange the 9 key causes of the Great War into a 'Diamond 9' shape, placing the most significant long-term or short-term cause at the top and the least significant at the bottom. Write two short paragraphs justifying your top choice and your bottom choice.

Diamond 9 Workspace



Factors to sort:

- The Assassination of Franz Ferdinand (The Spark)
- The Alliance System dividing Europe
- Germany's 'Blank Cheque' to Austria
- Anglo-German Naval Race (Militarism)
- The scramble for Imperial colonies in Africa
- Serbian Nationalism (The Black Hand)
- Russian Mobilisation schedules
- The Schlieffen Plan's invasion of Belgium
- The decline of the Ottoman Empire (Balkan instability)

Top Choice Justification:

Bottom Choice Justification:

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Assessment Option 3: Source Utility Analysis

Instructions: Study Sources B and C below. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the causes of the Great War? (8 marks)

Source B

Extract from the memoirs of the German Chancellor, Theobald von Bethmann Hollweg, published in 1919.

The terrible war was triggered by the brutal assassination of the Archduke in Sarajevo. However, the true cause was that Germany was surrounded by hostile enemies. The secret alliance system meant that when Russia began moving its vast army to defend Serbia, Germany was forced to defend itself. We did not want this war; we were forced into it by the aggressive alliances of our enemies.

Source C

Extract from the Treaty of Versailles, Article 231 (The 'War Guilt Clause'), signed by the victorious Allies in June 1919.

The Allied Governments demand, and Germany accepts, full responsibility for causing all the terrible loss and damage of the war. This devastating war was forced upon the world solely by the aggression of Germany and her allies.

Use the writing lines below to answer the 8-mark question. Remember to analyze the content, provenance, and apply your contextual knowledge for both sources.

Assessment Option 4: The Historians' Debate

Instructions: Study Interpretations 1 and 2 below, which match Sources B and C from the previous assessment. Then answer the three Edexcel GCSE Paper 3 questions.

Interpretation 1

No single nation can be entirely blamed for starting the First World War. The spark was the tragic assassination in Sarajevo, but the real problem was the rigid system of alliances. When the crisis erupted, leaders across all major powers blundered into a war they did not want, dragged along by secret treaties and the fear of being attacked first.

Interpretation 2

The outbreak of the First World War was entirely the fault of Germany's aggressive militarism. The German leadership deliberately encouraged Austria to attack Serbia, giving them a 'blank cheque' of support. Germany used the assassination in Sarajevo as a convenient excuse to launch a massive war and conquer Europe.

1. What is the main difference between Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 regarding who was to blame for the war? (4 marks)

**2. Suggest one reason why Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 give different views.
You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)**

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

End of Unit Quiz Pack

Instructions: Answer the 50 quick-fire recall questions below. If you get stuck, the scrambled answers are provided in the Answer Bank on the final page.

1. In what year did the Franco-Prussian War end?

2. Which wealthy region did Germany take from France in 1871?

3. What was the French desire for revenge called?

4. Who was the German Chancellor that unified Germany?

5. What was Bismarck's greatest strategic fear?

6. Which two countries did Bismarck fear would ally against Germany?

7. What was the secret 1887 agreement between Germany and Russia?

8. Which ambitious German Emperor dismissed Bismarck in 1890?

9. What was Wilhelm II's aggressive global policy called?

10. What previous policy of Bismarck's focused on European peace?

11. What agreement did Britain and France sign in 1904?

12. In which African country did Wilhelm provoke crises in 1905 and 1911?

13. What was the result of the First Moroccan (Tangier) Crisis?

14. What name was given to Germany's aggressive threat of military force?

15. What was the name of the German gunboat sent to Agadir in 1911?

17. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

19. What was Britain's traditional foreign policy of avoiding European alliances called?

21. What volatile region was known as the 'Powder Keg of Europe'?

23. Which empire was retreating from the Balkans, leaving a power vacuum?

25. Which region did Austria-Hungary formally annex in 1908?

27. Who was the heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne?

29. On what date was the Archduke assassinated?

16. What was the British policy requiring their navy to be larger than the next two combined?

18. Why did the Dreadnought ironically threaten British supremacy?

20. What was German Admiral Tirpitz's naval strategy called?

22. What declining multi-ethnic empire dominated the northern Balkans?

24. Which nation wanted to unite all South Slavs into a 'Greater' nation?

26. Which major power considered itself the protector of the Slavic people?

28. In which city was the Archduke assassinated?

30. Who assassinated the Archduke?

31. What secret Serbian society did the assassin belong to?

33. What is the month of diplomatic failures after the assassination called?

35. Which country began mobilizing its army to protect Serbia?

37. Which neutral country did Germany invade to attack France?

39. What was the alliance of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy called?

41. What treaty ended the First World War in 1919?

43. What is the term for a war launched to destroy a rising threat before it gets too strong?

45. Which historian argued the nations blundered into war due to rigid alliances?

32. What unconditional promise did Germany give Austria-Hungary in July 1914?

34. What did Austria-Hungary issue to Serbia on July 23?

36. What was the name of Germany's military strategy for a two-front war?

38. Which country declared war on Germany due to the invasion of Belgium?

40. What was the alliance of Britain, France, and Russia called?

42. Which clause forced Germany to accept full responsibility for the war?

44. Which historian famously argued Germany planned a war of aggression?

46. What was the 'quarantine line' of new states created after WWI called?

47. Name one new state created by the Treaty of Versailles.

48. What European power was completely dismantled by the peace treaties?

49. What ideological threat did the Allies want to separate from Germany after the war?

50. Which country did Germany invade on 3 August 1914?

Quiz Pack Answer Bank

1871 • A war on two fronts (Encirclement) • Alsace-Lorraine • An ultimatum • Archduke Franz Ferdinand • Article 231 (War Guilt Clause) • Belgium • Belgium • Bosnia • Britain • Britain and France grew closer, isolating Germany • Cordon Sanitaire • France and Russia • Fritz Fischer • Gavrilo Princip • Gunboat Diplomacy • HMS Dreadnought • It made all older ships obsolete, resetting the naval race • June 28, 1914 • Kaiser Wilhelm II • Margaret MacMillan • Morocco • Otto von Bismarck • Poland • Preventative War • Realpolitik • Revanche • Risk Theory • Russia • Russia • Sarajevo • Serbia • SMS Panther • Soviet Communism • Splendid Isolation • The 'Blank Check' • The Austro-Hungarian Empire • The Austro-Hungarian Empire • The Balkans • The Black Hand • The Entente Cordiale • The July Crisis • The Ottoman Empire • The Reinsurance Treaty • The Schlieffen Plan • The Treaty of Versailles • The Triple Alliance • The Triple Entente • The Two-Power Standard • Weltpolitik (World Policy)